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iPod docks

Agent 001 goes shopping for a companion to his favourite music player

Agent 001

agent001@thinkdigit.com

“An iPod dock? Yech. Who listens to music on those crummy things?”

That's the kind of sentiment I've always had towards iPod docks since the beginning. But before you label me as an elitist understand this – I am one. Of course I kid! But the fact is I want my audio without making any kind of concessions, especially those arising out of form. Hearing news of Behringer launching a monstrosity called iNuke Boom, I decided it's about time I paid a little more attention to this category. I'm talking about an iPod Dock that's a whopping 8 feet wide by 4 feet tall, weighs over 700 pounds and pumps out over 10,000 watts of power. Supposed to be the world's loudest iPod dock, it's so huge that an iPod looks like a mere speck on this behemoth's back.

Soon I began wondering about iPod docks closer to home. While I'd love to own Behringer's masterpiece, I'm sure I'll have better use for \$29,999.

So who are iPod docks meant for? I'd say they are meant for casual listening. I've had an iPod Touch for quite some time and I swear by it, but for me the iPod has exclusively been an on-the-go sort of companion. But come to think of it, I wouldn't mind plonking it into a dock as soon as I entered my living room and listen while I relax or unwind for the day. Another great use for a dock is in the great outdoors. As strange as it may sound, I've been to many a beach party where the old bonfire of yesteryear was replaced by – you guessed it – an iPod dock.

Within a month or so of window shopping I quickly came up with a few important considerations that go into the buying



decision. As always audio quality is of paramount importance. At the higher end of the price spectrum I debuted the Bose SoundDock 10 (~₹42,000). A friend was kind enough to let me keep it for a week, during which I even opened it up to try and understand how Bose's Waveguide technology works to amplify sound. It helps that no one knows I'm Agent001!

While spending ₹42,000 on a music system isn't unheard of, was the Bose SoundDock the best bang for my buck? Not quite. After listening to the wood bodied Philips DS9000 I was mighty impressed, and it's also a little cheaper compared to Bose. It packs in a few more features as well such as a custom app that gives you access to hundreds of internet radio stations with metadata tagging and social functionality. And it can double up as an alarm clock. A remote that lets you control the iPod is also very important – you'd want to be able to go back a level, change artists and playlists, control volume, etc.

At a lower price bracket I found many interesting options – most of which were portable. The Creative Zii Sound D5 is an odd specimen. Apart from being a regular iPod dock it can play wirelessly over bluetooth. Did it lose fidelity while transmitting over such a lossy protocol? Nope, thanks to the apt-X codec. Despite this, the sound quality, however, left a lot to be desired. Priced at around ₹18,000, I decided to give it a skip for now and continue looking.

The Philips DS1100 looked attractive and had decent sound quality for its reasonable ₹4,999 price tag. In the same price range, the Logitech Mini Boombox came highly recommended by a few friends but I wasn't able to get my hands on a unit to audition the sound quality. By now, the prospect of portability seemed to be more appealing to me than anything else. I looked at the JBL On Stage IV, which looked fantastic and could go mobile on six AA batteries. The sound quality was nothing to write home about though. From the Philips stable, I tried out the SBD 7500 which paled in looks to the JBL, but redeemed itself by offering audio performance that was a notch higher. It lasted for about four hours on a set of four regular (non-Duracell) batteries at full volume.

The trouble with all these portable pipsqueaks was just that: they were like I said, pipsqueaks. Could there be something that offers decent punch while not burning a hole in my pocket? Logitech's S715i seemed to come close. The dock has a whole bunch of drivers and can run on rechargeable nickel-metal hydride batteries. It packs a punch even if the audio quality isn't exactly pristine. Priced at about Rs. 13,000, I think I'd found the iPod dock for me.

For those of you who find the price tag alarming and just want a bedside alarm+docking solution, I'd recommend the The Philips DS1100. For those who want extreme portability Philips' SBD 7500 is a slim and decently loud option. Well at least now you have a wisecrack to offer anyone who throws that old cliché your way, “What's up dock?”. 

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TURN TO PAGE 2